I had to dig deep, work bloody hard for every single run I scored down the years. Ambition is double-edged. I remembered being in a lift at Edgbaston with Michael Vaughan early in my career, when he told me I could score 10,000 Test runs. That very quietly became a huge goal of mine. When I fulfilled it, a tiny light went out.

Looking back, that was because I realized it would never get easier, and I needed additional motivation. I spent the next six months or so searching for what, deep down, I knew would be an artificial target. I thought about seeking forty Test hundreds, and ended with thirty-three, but I never found what I was looking for, a goal that consumed me. The fact I can live comfortably with that tells me there wasn't too much substance to the quest.

Unusually, I slept well the night before the final Test began. I didn't need to use the trick I developed on the road with Graeme Swann, where alarms would be set for 2 a.m., so we could go straight back to sleep in the knowledge we had another four hours before the pressure ratcheted up again. Barking mad, against the logic of sports science, but effective, without preventing the anxiety dreams which assail many batsmen.

In the classic cricket dream I'm waiting to bat. I know I will be timed out if I can't get my kit on, and I'm thrashing around, trying to find my pads. I have two other recurring dreams; in the first I go for an easy three, but I'm run out by half a pitch because it is as if my legs are trapped in treacle. In the second I'm playing indoors while everyone else is playing outdoors; instead of getting a boundary when I find the gap, the ball rebounds off the wall to the bowler, who runs me out.

I've always been an early bird, so leaving the team hotel near Tower Bridge at 8 a.m. felt like a lie in. For the first time, a group of us, including Jimmy, Keaton Jennings and James Foster, the former England wicketkeeper who has been a long-term teammate at Essex, decided to travel by Tube; one stop on the District line, five more on the Northern line and we were there. A few commuters did a double take, and we took a photograph for posterity, but it was hassle free.

At 10.15 we began warming up, which can be incredibly dull. I have such respect for athletes who are enslaved by conditioning coaches, doing plyometrics day in, day out. There's no need for such regimentation in international cricket, because players know their own roles and listen to their bodies. We slip into individual routines once the toss is conducted, half an hour before play.